

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

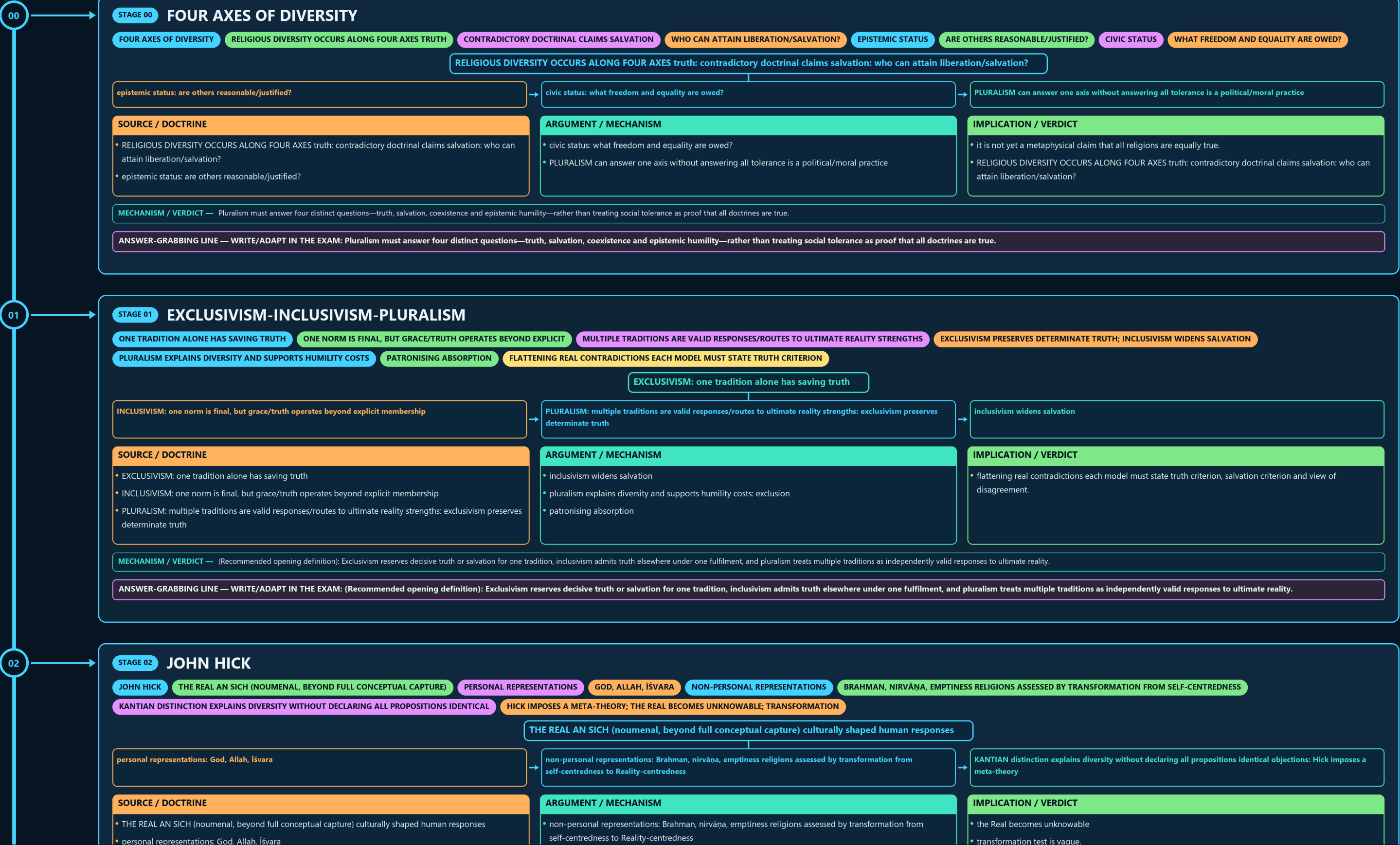
FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY → EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM → JOHN HICK → VEDĀNTIC MODELS → JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS → TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g9 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



- **INCLUSIVISM:** one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membership
- **PLURALISM:** multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truth

- pluralism explains diversity and supports humility costs: exclusion
- patronising absorption

disagreement.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: (Recommended opening definition): Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfilment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.

## 02

## STAGE 02 JOHN HICK

JOHN HICK   THE REAL AN SICH (NOUMENAL, BEYOND FULL CONCEPTUAL CAPTURE)   PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS   GOD, ALLAH, ÍŚVARA   NON-PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS   BRAHMAN, NIRVĀṆA, EMPTINESS RELIGIONS ASSESSED BY TRANSFORMATION FROM SELF-CENTREDNESS

KANTIAN DISTINCTION EXPLAINS DIVERSITY WITHOUT DECLARING ALL PROPOSITIONS IDENTICAL      HICK IMPOSES A META-THEORY; THE REAL BECOMES UNKNOWABLE; TRANSFORMATION

**THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses**

**personal representations: God, Allah, Īśvara**

- ▶ **non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness**

→ KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

**SOURCE / DOCTRINE**

- THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses
- personal representations: God, Allah, Īśvara

**ARGUMENT / MECHANISM**

- non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness
- KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

### IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- the Real becomes unknowable
- transformation test is vague.

**MECHANISM / VERDICT** — Hick explains religions as culturally mediated responses to the Real, but the unknowability of the Real threatens to make the hypothesis unverifiable and covertly privileged.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM:** Hick explains religions as culturally mediated responses to the Real, but the unknowability of the Real threatens to make the hypothesis unverifiable and covertly privileged.

## 03

## STAGE 03 VEDĀNTIC MODELS

VEDĀNTIC MODELS    ONE BRAHMAN; DIFFERENCES BELONG TO EMPIRICAL STANDPOINT    MANY PATHS MAY PREPARE FOR NON-DUAL KNOWLEDGE    REAL PLURALITY WITHIN BRAHMAN'S UNITY; DEVOTION TO PERSONAL GOD    DIVERSE RELIGIOUS PATHS CAN REALISE ONE ULTIMATE

ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM IF ALL VIEWS ARE PARTIAL, IS "ALL" REPLY REQUIRES STANDPOINT DISCIPLINE, NOT EFFORTLESS EQUIVALENCE OF INCOMPATIBLE

| SYSTEM / DOCTRINE                                                                                                                                                          | DECISIVE DISTINCTION                                                                                                                                                                                                        | EVALUATION / TRAP                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint                                                                                                           | RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final                                                                                                                                     | ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?                                                                                                                                                      |
| many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge                                                                                                                              | RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate                                                                                                                                                     | reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>SYSTEM / DOCTRINE</b>                                                                                                                                                   | <b>DECISIVE DISTINCTION</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>EVALUATION / TRAP</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint</li><li>• many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final</li><li>• RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?</li><li>• reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.</li></ul> |

**MECHANISM / VERDICT —** Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM:** Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

## 04

STAGE 04 JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS    REALITY HAS MANY ASPECTS    EACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINT    PREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USE    RIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSION

EPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMIT   
 CONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFER   
 SYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

**ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects**

**NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint**

→ SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different

→ possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

**SOURCE / DOCTRINE**

- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects
- NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

**ARGUMENT / MECHANISM**

- SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive
- possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only

### IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- syādvāda cannot simply pronounce every doctrine true in the same sense.
- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint
- many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final
- RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate

EVALUATION / TRAP

- ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
- reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

04

STAGE 04

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

REALITY HAS MANY ASPECTS

EACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINT

PREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USE

RIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSION

EPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMIT

CONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFER

SYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive

possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects
- NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive
- possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects genuinely differ

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- syādvāda cannot simply pronounce every doctrine true in the same sense.
- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality) and nayavāda (doctrine of partial standpoints) justify humility about perspectives without implying that contradictory propositions are simultaneously true in the same respect.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality) and nayavāda (doctrine of partial standpoints) justify humility about perspectives without implying that contradictory propositions are simultaneously true in the same respect.

05

STAGE 05

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

REFRAIN FROM COERCION DESPITE DISAGREEMENT RESPECT

RECOGNISE EQUAL STANDING

RECIPROCAL REASON-GIVING FREEDOM

BELIEF, PRACTICE, CHANGE OF RELIGION, NON-BELIEF, ASSOCIATION

LIMITS COERCION

HARM TO RIGHTS MAY BE REGULATED BUT OFFENCE OR

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- LIMITS coercion
- harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

06

STAGE 06

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT SOURCES

EXCLUSIVE REVELATION

SACRED HISTORY

GRIEVANCE RESPONSES

COMMON ETHICAL CORE

COMPARATIVE THEOLOGY

LEGAL NEUTRALITY

sacred history

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

grievance responses: syncretism

common ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation
- sacred history
- grievance responses: syncretism

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- common ethical core
- comparative theology
- legal neutrality

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap,
- preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH • TILE 3/4 • same master rows 4131-7365 of 9430 • continues below

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

- LIMITS coercion
- harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

06

STAGE 06 CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT SOURCES

EXCLUSIVE REVELATION

SACRED HISTORY

GRIEVANCE RESPONSES

COMMON ETHICAL CORE

COMPARATIVE THEOLOGY

LEGAL NEUTRALITY

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred history

grievance responses: syncretism

common ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred history

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ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

common ethical core

comparative theology

legal neutrality

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap,

preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect

without equalising every truth claim.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect without equalising every truth claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Deep religious disagreement persists because evidence is interpreted through rival frameworks, yet rational dialogue remains possible through internal critique, shared reasons and epistemic humility.

07

STAGE 07 PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE AXIS

MAP EXCLUSIVISM/INCLUSIVISM/PLURALISM

EXPLAIN HICK EXACTLY

COMPARE ADVAITA/RĀMĀNUJA/JAIN ANEKĀNTA

TEST ABSOLUTE-TRUTH OBJECTION

MOVE FROM METAPHYSICAL DIVERSITY TO TOLERANCE/FREEDOM WITH LIMITS

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly

compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits

qualified conclusion

CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither "all religions say the same" nor relativism

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly

compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits

qualified conclusion

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither "all religions say the same" nor relativism

it combines truth-seeking, fallibilism, transformative comparison and equal civic liberty.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Pluralism need not deny absolute truth; it denies exhaustive possession of truth by any finite perspective and therefore supports a bounded, non-relativist openness.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism need not deny absolute truth; it denies exhaustive possession of truth by any finite perspective and therefore supports a bounded, non-relativist openness.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

DOCTRINE STATEMENT.

EXCLUSIVISM MAKES ONE TRADITION'S DECISIVE TRUTH/SALVATION CLAIM UNIQUELY VALID

INCLUSIVISM GRANTS TRUTH OR SALVATION BEYOND IT WHILE INTERPRETING

EXCLUSIVISM APPEALS TO DETERMINATE REVELATION AND NON-CONTRADICTION.

INCLUSIVISM ADDS UNIVERSALITY OF DIVINE GRACE WHILE PRESERVING NORMATIVE

PRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

Doctrine statement.

Exclusivism makes one tradition's decisive truth/salvation claim uniquely valid

inclusivism grants truth or salvation beyond it while interpreting that success through the home tradition.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

Argument.

Exclusivism appeals to determinate revelation and non-contradiction.

Inclusivism adds universality of divine grace while preserving normative priority.

Presupposition. CAUTION: One revelation has privileged warrant, and salvation can be specified independently enough to compare traditions.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

Distinction. Inclusivism is not pluralism: others are included on terms set by the privileged tradition.

Canonical example. Rahner's "anonymous Christian" is a standard inclusivist model.

Objection → reply.

CAUTION: Inclusivism appears patronising.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.